GLASSHOUSE

SONI AND SONIA



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

The recently concluded Congress Nav Sankalp Shivir in Udaipur resolved to reserve 50 per cent of all party positions for leaders under the age of 50. But the top leadership seems to value veterans more. After the death of Sonia Gandhi's political secretary Ahmed Patel in 2020, the Congress president seems to have found a trusted lieutenant in **Ambika Soni**. The 79-year-old Rajya Sabha member from Punjab is part of all top party committees. She was the only leader to have travelled with Sonia in her aircraft to Udaipur. Not surprising that former Punjab Congress chief Sunil Jakhar, while quitting, directed his anger at Soni for allegedly messing up affairs in Punjab. Soni now has a battle to fight—her RS tenure ends in July. Re-election chances from Punjab are slim. Too many claimants, few states with winning arithmetic for Congress make her return even more difficult. Will Madam come to her rescue?

Bend it Like Didi



ANI

After Bengal lost to Kerala in the Santosh Trophy final, state sports minister **Aroop Biswas** gave the team a portrait of Mamata Banerjee, asking them to put the picture on their walls and draw inspiration from how a girl from a disadvantaged background made it to the top. He could just as well have used the image of Mamata kicking a football with her plastered leg, which became the leitmotif for the 2021 electoral battle between the TMC and the BJP. Didi can sure teach a lesson or two on how to turn around a game.

A NEAT BARGAIN

Pushed to a corner in Karnataka politics, former chief minister **B.S. Yediyurappa** has struck a compromise. At a BJP core group meeting, he offered not to stake claim to his Shikaripura constituency, assuring support to the party nominee there. He is seeking a legislative council ticket for younger son B.Y. Vijayendra. Many believe this can keep the Yediyurappa family interested and the Lingayat votes intact. He also said his family will not contest the upcoming assembly poll, only campaign for the party. The ball is now in the high command's court.



HEMANT MISHRA

–Kaushik Deka with Romita Datta, Anilesh S. Mahajan, Kiran D. Tare and Amarnath K. Menon



ANI

NEW MIMIC IN TOWN

An otherwise fiery orator, **Devendra Fadnavis** stunned the audience when he mimicked Uddhav Thackeray at a BJP rally in Mumbai on May 15. The leader of the Opposition modulated his voice, teasing the CM, and made fun of his body language while attacking his anti-BJP 'rhetoric'. He is no match for Raj Thackeray, though, inarguably the best mimic in Maharashtra politics. Fadnavis's comic turn in Raj's footsteps may be a new stage in their growing friendship. Should Uddhav worry?



Office Network

The Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS), steered by state chief minister **K. Chandrashekar Rao,** is adept at building assets. On May 11, a day after the Hyderabad Collector proposed allocation of 4,935 yards in posh Banjara Hills for the party's city office, chief secretary Somesh Kumar directed it to be finished fast. Except Warangal and Hyderabad, TRS has offices in the remaining 31 districts; KCR laid the foundation stone for one in Delhi last year. The latest allocation, despite TRS's state office nearby, is also on government-allotted land.